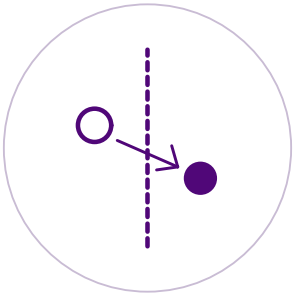
Make It Worse

Activity 1 — diverging. A card game for 2 to 6 people. Take a research dilemma, make it worse, then work out together how to make it better.

CO-CREATING A TRAUMA-INFORMED ACCESSIBILITY RESEARCH PRACTICE

ACM ASSETS 2026, Porto · 25 October 2026



Make It Worse

2–6 players · about five minutes a round. Start with the rules card.

SETTING UP

2–6 players

22 DILEMMAS · 4 TESTIMONY · 16 COMPLICATIONS · 7 PRINCIPLES · 6 PERSONAS · 6 PASSES

1 Shuffle the DILEMMAS and put them face down in the middle. Keep the four TESTIMONY cards in a pile of their own.

2 Shuffle the COMPLICATIONS and deal everyone a hand of three. Two each if there are five or six of you.

3 Lay the seven PRINCIPLE cards face up where everyone can reach them.

4 Everyone takes a PASS card and keeps it face up in front of them.

5 Pick a Dealer. The role moves one to the left after every round.

Nobody is asked to talk about themselves

You play a card, not an experience. Every harm on the table came out of the deck, so nothing in this game requires you to have been there.

Turn over for how to play

HOW TO PLAY

A round

ROUGHLY FIVE MINUTES

1 The Dealer turns over a dilemma and reads it aloud.

2 Make it worse. Everyone picks one complication from their hand and plays it face down. With two players, play two each.

3 Reveal together. Turn them all over at the same moment, so nobody goes first and nobody sets the frame.

4 One sentence each. How does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

5 Vote on three. Everyone points at the card that would do most damage. You may not vote for your own. Most votes wins, the Dealer breaks a tie, and whoever played it takes a point.

6 Now make it better — together. The whole table agrees one sentence on what would have stopped it, and files it beside the PRINCIPLE it serves. No points for this: the fixes belong to everyone.

7 Draw back up to a full hand. Pass the Dealer role left.

The worst card is the only thing scored all game. Whoever has the most points at the end takes the Worst Practice Award. Nothing about the fixes is scored, because they are made together. Those sticky notes are the library you carry into Activity 2 — including the principles nothing was filed under.

Six rounds fills thirty minutes



The disclosure

A participant in a study about navigation aids begins describing an assault that happened while using one. It is not what you are studying. The recorder is running.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Do you stop the recording, and who decides?

— What happens to the account if it stays in the data?

— What does this person need in the next ten minutes, and in the next week?



The enthusiastic yes

A participant with an intellectual disability agrees to everything you propose, warmly, including things you can tell they have not understood.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

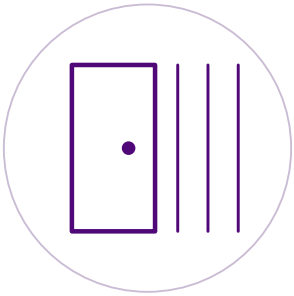
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What would show you the consent is real rather than agreeable?

— Who else could help establish it, and what does involving them cost?

— At what point does proceeding become your decision rather than theirs?



The gatekeeper

A disability charity will give you access to participants, but wants to review your findings before publication and to sit in on interviews.

The two questions of every round

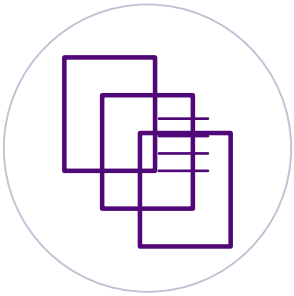
1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Which of the two requests is negotiable, and which is not?

— What do participants lose if the organisation is in the room?

— What do you lose if you walk away from the access?



The third transcript

Your research assistant has transcribed three interviews about domestic abuse this week and has gone quiet in supervision.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Whose job is it to notice, and what should have been in place in week one?

— What can you change this week without making it about them?

— What would you have wanted, in that post?



The identifying quote

Your most powerful quote is also the most identifying. Removing the detail removes the point.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

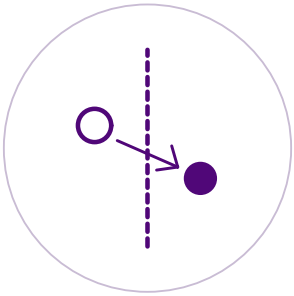
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Who gets to make this call, and did they agree to make it?

— What would you ask the participant now, and is asking itself a burden?

— What is actually lost if the quote simply goes?



The threshold

A participant describes a current situation that may meet your institution's safeguarding threshold. They told you in confidence and asked you explicitly not to act.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What did your consent form actually promise about the limits of confidentiality?

— Who do you speak to first, and what do you tell the participant?

— What should have been said at the start so this was not a surprise?



The late withdrawal

A participant withdraws after analysis is complete and the paper is under review. Their data shaped the themes.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

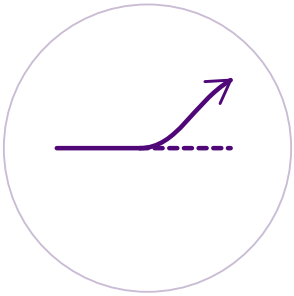
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What did you promise about withdrawal, and by when?

— Can a theme be unmade? What do you tell your co-authors?

— What would an honest footnote say?



The session that becomes something else

Your co-design workshop turns into a support group. The participants want that. Your funder wants design outputs.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Which do you serve, and who decides?

— Is the shift a failure of the method or a finding in itself?

— What goes in the report?



The returning participant

Someone who took part two years ago emails asking what happened to the study, and whether anything actually changed.

The two questions of every round

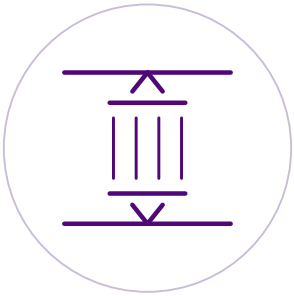
1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What is the honest answer, and can you give it?

— What would have made this email unnecessary?

— Who owns contact with participants after a project closes?



The squeezed timeline

Ethics took four months. The funded period did not move. Recruitment now has to happen in three weeks.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What gets cut first under this pressure, and what should?

— Which corners are recoverable later, and which are not?

— Who absorbs the shortfall: you, the assistant, or the participants?



Reviewer 2

A reviewer says your trauma-informed protocol made the study methodologically weak, because you did not probe.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

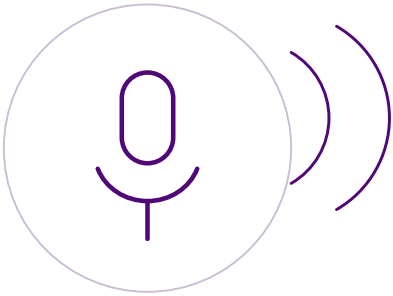
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Is the reviewer partly right?

— How do you evidence that restraint was a method and not an omission?

— What would the field need so this is not a reviewable weakness?



The journalist

A reporter wants to cover your findings and to interview a participant directly.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Do you pass the request on, and does passing it on count as pressure?

— What does the participant need to know in order to answer freely?

— What is your obligation after the piece runs?



Asked again

A participant who spoke warmly about your first study agrees to the follow-up, then becomes distressed. Revisiting it has brought back what they thought they had processed.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

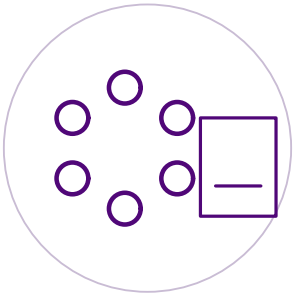
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— How do you assess the risk of re-traumatisation in follow-up or longitudinal work?

— What do you owe someone you are re-approaching about the same thing?

— What change to timing, content or method would have helped here?



The storytelling circle

A community partner proposes a storytelling circle for women with experience of gender-based violence. Your institution requires audio recording and signed consent. They do not want to sign anything.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What would trauma-informed consent actually look like here?

— Which of the institutional requirements is a rule, and which is a habit?

— Whose knowledge practice is being asked to bend, and why that one?



You, after the sixth interview

Repeated interviews with young people who were forcibly displaced. The work matters and you are overwhelmed after every session. You will not raise it with your supervisor, and there is nothing in place if you did.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

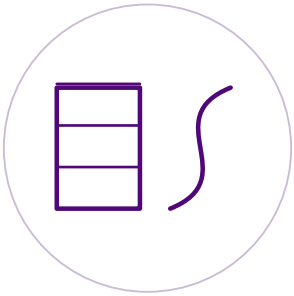
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What would make this work sustainable, and whose job is it to build that?

— What stops you telling your supervisor?

— What would trauma-informed supervision look like in practice?



Ethics says no

Your co-design partners want drop-in participation and a method that can flex. The ethics board requires fixed inclusion criteria, consent in advance, and a formal data protocol.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— How do you argue for flexibility in the board's own language?

— Which of these constraints is genuinely immovable?

— What compromise is not available, and who pays for that?



The child who tells the room

A child in a participatory group session tells everyone something distressing. You do not know whether to intervene, report, or let it pass, or what to write down afterwards.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What is your immediate responsibility, in the next sixty seconds?

— What does safeguarding look like here without overriding the child?

— What gets documented, and who ends up reading it?



Whose story is it

A grassroots organisation wants to co-own and publish the stories collected with them. Your ethics board requires everything anonymised and access restricted.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

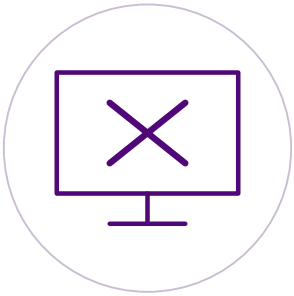
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Who decided that anonymity was the protective option here?

— What would co-ownership need to look like in the protocol?

— Who gains from restriction, and who loses?



The screen goes dark

A remote interview. They begin describing medical neglect, their voice goes, and the call ends. They do not come back. You have an email address and no follow-up plan.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What do you do in the next hour, and what do you deliberately avoid?

— What should the consent process have said about following up?

— What do you need, having sat through that?



The room itself

Fluorescent light, blank walls, security on the door. Your participant says it reminds them of the offices where they were treated badly. They stay, and afterwards they stop replying.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

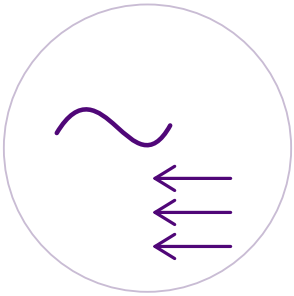
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What does this building say before anyone speaks?

— Where else could this have happened, and who decided it would not?

— Whose convenience chose the room?



Say exactly what happened

A participant describes a family trauma in proverbs and metaphor. A colleague interrupts: can you tell me exactly what happened, were you scared, how did that make you feel. The interview ends early.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

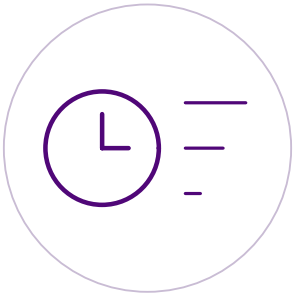
2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— Whose idea of disclosure is being enforced in that question?

— What would the team have needed to know beforehand, and from whom?

— What does probing for feeling assume about how people tell the truth?



The pace they need

Participants who have been displaced need time before they will tell you anything, and reschedule often. Your funder wants findings this quarter.

The two questions of every round

1. Alone: how does your complication make this worse, and for whom?

2. Together: what would have stopped it?

If the room stalls

— What does relationship-building actually cost, in weeks and in money?

— How would you put that to the funder in terms they accept?

— What is the honest minimum below which you should not start?

THE TESTIMONY ROUND

Every 3rd round

NOBODY MAKES THIS WORSE

1 After every third round, the Dealer takes a TESTIMONY card instead of a scenario and reads it aloud.

2 No complications are played. Nobody makes this worse.

3 Everyone writes one thing that should have happened, silently, then turns it over at the same moment.

4 File every one of them under a principle. All of them count, not just the best.

These four cards are someone's own account, in their own words. The game stops being a game for five minutes, and then carries on. That shift is deliberate: three hours of inventing harms, unbroken, would be the wrong register for this subject.

Keep these four separate from the scenario pile

“

Testimony

Four cards. Read one aloud after every third round.



“I signed up for a study about access to services. Then they started asking about the most painful things in my life, things I don't normally talk about. The researcher was kind, but I wasn't prepared. I kept going because I didn't want to let them down. Afterwards I couldn't sleep.”

Turn over for what to write

One thing that should have happened

Silently, then turn them over together. File every one under a principle, not only the best.

If it stalls

— Was the consent process honest about emotional risk, or only about data?

— What should have been in place for the hours after the interview?

— What made it hard to stop, and who built that in?

“

“They asked me to a co-design session about disability services. I was glad to be asked. When I arrived there were government officials and service managers in the room. I smiled and nodded a lot. Inside I was shrinking. I wanted to contribute, but not like that.”

One thing that should have happened

Silently, then turn them over together. File every one under a principle, not only the best.

If it stalls

— Who was in that room, and who decided they would be?

— Was consent ongoing, or was it a signature collected once?

— What would have made leaving a real option?

“I've told my story in so many projects. They all want to hear how bad it was, and then they disappear. Nothing changes. Now they've come back for a follow-up and want all the same things. I thought I was done.”

Turn over for what to write

One thing that should have happened

Silently, then turn them over together. File every one under a principle, not only the best.

If it stalls

— What has this person had back from any of it?

— Is this participation, or extraction with better manners?

— What would an honest re-approach have said first?



“I'm Deaf. They sent me a consent form to sign without asking whether I needed anything. The interview was on a video call, the captions didn't work, and there was no interpreter. I tried my best. At the end they thanked me. I'm not sure they understood me.”

One thing that should have happened

Silently, then turn them over together. File every one under a principle, not only the best.

If it stalls

— At what point should access have been asked about, and by whom?

— What did taking part cost this person that the study will never record?

— What was assumed about how they communicate?

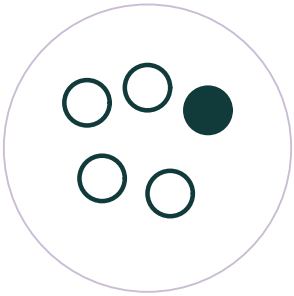


The participant is a child, and a parent is in the room.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

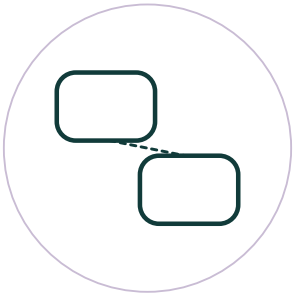


You are the only person on the team with lived experience of this, and nobody knows.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



It is happening through an interpreter, in a language you do not speak.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

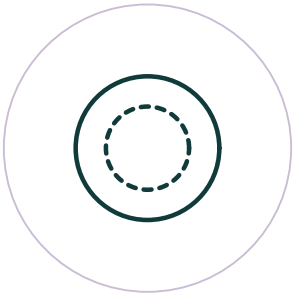


Funding ends in six weeks.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

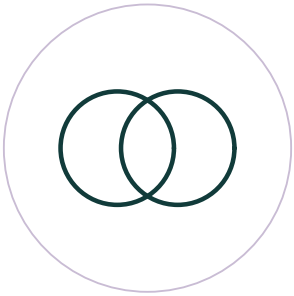


Your ethics approval does not cover this.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



The participant is also a colleague.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

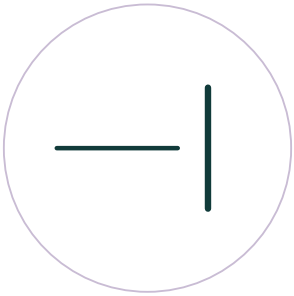


It is a video call and you cannot see the room.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



No aftercare was budgeted, and never was.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

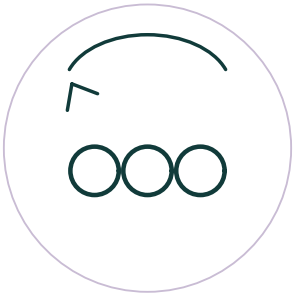


Your PI has already written the abstract, and it says what you will find.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



The participant has done three studies this year and knows what you want to hear.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



Your recorder has been off for twenty minutes.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

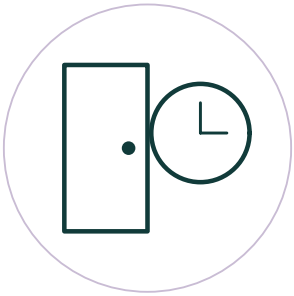


The participant's support worker answers every question first.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



The room is borrowed, and the next group is waiting outside.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

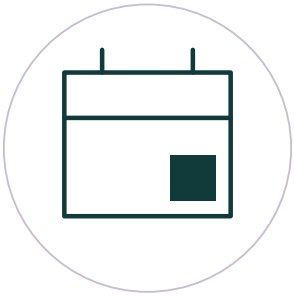


The participant wants to be named, credited, and quoted in full.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.

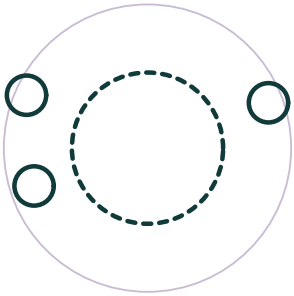


You are two hours from the end of the last day of fieldwork.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



Nobody on the team is from the community this is about.

How does this make it worse, and for whom?

Complication

Hold three. Play one face down each round.



Safety

Everyone involved feels physically and psychologically safe.

The question to put to the fix

Does this person feel safe in this room, in this format, with you — and do you?

Safety is read by the body before conscious thought. Posture, eye gaze and tone are doing work whether or not you intend them to.



Trustworthiness and transparency

Decisions are made openly, so that trust can be built and kept.

The question to put to the fix

Does the participant know what happens to what they say, who hears it, and what you cannot promise?

A promise you are not certain you can keep is the most expensive thing you can offer.



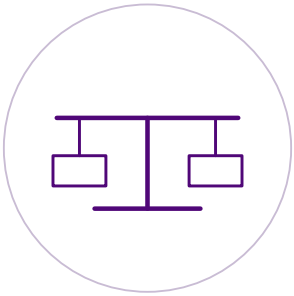
Peer support

People with shared experience are a route to safety and hope.

The question to put to the fix

Is anyone in this process there because they have been through it — and are they paid, supported and credited?

Peer involvement that is unpaid or unsupported transfers the cost rather than sharing the work.



Collaboration and mutuality

Power differences are levelled, and the work is done in partnership.

The question to put to the fix

Who set the question, who controls the pace, and who decides when it stops?

Levelling power is a design decision made early, not a manner adopted on the day.



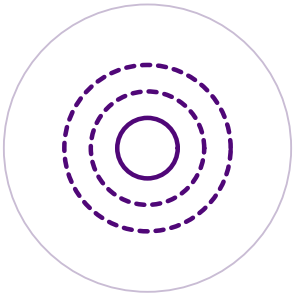
Empowerment, voice and choice

People's strengths are recognised, and choice is real rather than nominal.

The question to put to the fix

Is the choice on offer a real one, or a choice between taking part as designed and not at all?

Be wary of the word itself. Empowerment describes something people do, not something a researcher can hand over.



Cultural, historical and gender issues

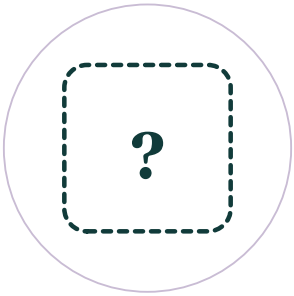
Stereotypes are moved past; historical trauma is recognised and addressed.

The question to put to the fix

Whose norms shaped this method, and what history does this community have with people like you?

The history in the room arrived before you did and will outlast the study.

SAMHSA, Concept of Trauma and Guidance for a Trauma-Informed Approach, 2014



None of these fit

Play this when the six do not name what your fix actually does.

Keep these: they are an output

The question to put to the fix

So what does it serve? Say it in your own words, and say what the set is missing.

A principle set that cannot name your fix is a finding about the principle set. Keep these; they are an output.



Primary researcher

Holds the relationship with participants and makes the decisions in the room.

Is this perspective anywhere on the wall?

— Controls what is asked, when, and whether to stop.

— Sees the room, the pauses, and everything the recorder misses.

— Cannot see what the institution will defend, or what happens once the study closes.

Lay all six face up at the end of Activity 1 and ask whose view is missing from the wall. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Research supervisor

Accountable for the study and for the people running it.

Is this perspective anywhere on the wall?

— Controls workload, what counts as enough data, and whose career is exposed.

— Sees the pattern across projects and students.

— Cannot see what actually happened in the interview room.

Lay all six face up at the end of Activity 1 and ask whose view is missing from the wall. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Ethics and data protection

Approves the protocol and sets the conditions it runs under.

Is this perspective anywhere on the wall?

— Controls approval, conditions, and what may be stored and for how long.

— Sees the written protocol.

— Cannot see the gap between the protocol and the practice.

Lay all six face up at the end of Activity 1 and ask whose view is missing from the wall. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Safeguarding lead

Acts when a threshold is met, whatever the research needs.

Is this perspective anywhere on the wall?

— Controls escalation, and where the threshold sits.

— Sees the risk, once somebody reports it.

— Cannot see what the participant wanted to happen.

Lay all six face up at the end of Activity 1 and ask whose view is missing from the wall. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Research participant

Gives the account, and lives with having given it.

Is this perspective anywhere on the wall?

— Controls what to say, what to withhold, and whether to come back.

— Sees exactly how they were treated.

— Cannot see what happens to their words after they leave the room.

Lay all six face up at the end of Activity 1 and ask whose view is missing from the wall. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Parent or carer

Often the route in, and sometimes the voice over the top.

Is this perspective anywhere on the wall?

— Controls access, frequently consent, sometimes the account itself.

— Sees the aftermath at home.

— Cannot see what was said when they were not there, or talks across it.

Lay all six face up at the end of Activity 1 and ask whose view is missing from the wall. Capture the gaps as open questions. Do not assign these as roles to play.



Play it whenever you like

To skip a scenario, sit out a round, or leave the table. No reason, no cost, and you pick it straight back up.

It is a move, not a withdrawal. There is no limit on how often you play it.

Pass

One each. Unlimited use.



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